

Individual Training – Key Takeaways

Adult Learning Principles in Defence Training, Sessions 1–4

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Commander's Question

What is the Army approach to individual training?

A working synthesis of the evidence so far, to be tested and refined as the activity continues.

Emerging Takeaways

- 1 Individual training exists to produce operational competence.** Course completion is a means, not the end. Success is whether an individual can perform to the required standard, in role and under operational conditions.
- 2 The standard is common; the learning journey need not be identical.** Individuals arrive with different experience, competence and learning needs. Army should provide appropriate routes to the same required standard while maintaining operational assurance.
- 3 Competence develops progressively through practice, experience and feedback.** Training should move deliberately from foundation knowledge and guided practice toward independent application, judgement and performance under pressure.
- 4 The level of direction should change as competence grows.** Foundational and high-risk training requires greater standardisation and instructor control. As competence develops, learner autonomy, complexity, experiential learning and reflection can increase.
- 5 Individual training extends beyond the course.** Formal instruction, digital and distributed learning, simulation, coaching, workplace experience, feedback and reinforcement are complementary parts of one continuous system. Learning should be accessible before, during and after formal training.
- 6 The method is selected to achieve the outcome.** Instructors, technology, learning frameworks, simulation, data and AI are enablers, not the Army approach itself. Their value is in improving practice, feedback, adaptation and evidence of performance while maintaining the required standard.
- 7 Competent use of these tools is itself a training requirement.** Investment in technology does not by itself produce capability; the gain comes from people who are practised in using it. Army should develop this like any other skill, through deliberate practice, time to experiment and tolerance for early failure.

Emerging Model

Foundation → Guided Practice → Independent Practice → Applied / Experiential Learning → Performance Under Pressure

Across this progression:

Instructor direction decreases while learner autonomy, complexity and pressure increase.

How far and how fast an individual progresses is determined by:

Risk × Complexity × Learner Competence × Required Operational Outcome

Individual training continues across a career through a recurring cycle:

Prepare → Learn → Practise → Apply → Perform → Feedback → Reinforce / Adapt

Emerging Proposition

Army develops individuals progressively and continuously toward operational competence, combining direction, practice, experience, coaching and learner agency according to risk, complexity, learner competence and the required operational outcome.

The standard is common; the journey to it need not be identical.

An emerging proposition based on the evidence from the first four sessions, to be tested against those still to come.